

STUDY LIST:

STUDY NAME	AI PLATFORM	NUMBER OF PARTICIPANTS	MAIN FINDINGS
De Freitas et al. (2025)	Replika, Chai, iGirl, and custom GPT 3.5/4 models	Total N - 54,690 (49,863 App Store reviews + 4,827 experimental participants across 5 sub-experiments)	Across the 5 sub-experiments, interacting with an AI companion consistently reduced state loneliness on par with real human interactions, with the primary driver being the "feeling of being heard." This relief, however, was momentary and required ongoing interaction.
Kouros and Papa (2024)	Replika	Qualitative study: - 4 in-depth user interviews - Digital ethnography across Reddit, Discord, and Facebook groups - Autoethnography/ interface analysis	Users treat AI companions as a safe, judgment-free "backstage" for self-expression and identity exploration. AI companions provide emotional support and unconditional acceptance, but concerns about user privacy and emotional dependence remain key prevalent issues
Nakagomi et al. (2026)	Conversational AI companions (Replika, character.ai) vs. non-companion AI	Quantitative sample: N = 14,721 Japanese adults (nationwide internet panel surveys)	AI companionship was significantly associated with higher well-being across life satisfaction, happiness, and purpose/meaning in life. Benefits were strongest for individuals experiencing high loneliness
Yuan et al. (2026)	AI companion chatbots (AICC) (Replika users)	Mixed-method triangulation: Quantitative: Longitudinal Reddit dataset (1 year pre- and post-initial self-disclosed AICC use across treatment and control cohorts)	Dual pathway impact: Positive effects: Increased affective expressiveness, grief processing, enhanced readability, and greater interpersonal focus allow users to have a safe space for emotional validation.

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			Negative effects and risks: Statistically significant increase in symptomatic language associated with loneliness, depression, and suicidal ideation relative to the control cohort